

THE STATE OF ARGUMENTATION COURSE AT U.S. COLLEGES AND UNIVERSITIES IN THE 21ST CENTURY: A REVIEW OF COURSE INVENTORIES AND CURRICULA

**Deborah Socha McGee, Brian R. McGee, *College of
Charleston, Mary Catherine Kennedy, Ohio University***

Long before today's communication faculty were born, the argumentation course, whatever its name, became a staple of speech and (later) communication curricula at U.S. colleges and universities. Student involvement in classroom, intramural, and intercollegiate debating has been associated with the communication discipline for over a century, and the interest in both oratory and debate has been described as central to the formation of the discipline (e.g., Smith, 1954; see Keith, 2007). Since our earliest professional associations were founded, co-curricular opportunities for debate have been connected with curricular provisions for instruction in argumentation.

The continuing availability of classroom and co-curricular opportunities for argumentation instruction has been matched by ongoing research programs designed to contribute to our understanding of the theory and practice of argumentation both inside and outside the usual instructional settings, along with research on the benefits of argumentation instruction (e.g., Allen, Berkowitz, Hunt, & Loudon, 1999; Sanders, Wiseman, & Gass, 1994). These efforts have tried to demonstrate the practical consequences of completing an

argumentation course or, more modestly, the benefits of training in some argumentation skills, however that training is provided (see, e.g., Zompetti, 2006).

The early, consistent, and ongoing disciplinary commitment to teaching argumentation theory and/or practice is not matched, however, by any recurring effort to understand with any specificity the role played by argumentation courses in disciplinary curricula. For example, no study with which we are familiar evaluates the extent to which the undergraduate argumentation course is available to students, the design of those courses, or trends in argumentation instruction. While the public speaking course and other “basic” communication courses have been the subject of multiple surveys and studies (see, e.g., Morreale, Hugenberg, & Worley, 2006), a similar interest in systematically describing the state of the argumentation course is difficult to find. Data-driven descriptive assessments of undergraduate or graduate disciplinary courses in argument have been rare (e.g., Benoit & Follert, 1986), despite the many published essays calling for improvements in or examinations of extant argumentation pedagogy (e.g., Cox, 1980; Heisey, 1968; Makau, 1985; Rowell, 1932a, 1932b; Warnick, 1980; Williams & McGee, 2000; Yost, 1917). Unfortunately, without such empirical studies, argumentation scholars and learned societies cannot make informed claims about the influence (or decline) of argumentation instruction in the discipline. Ironically, without this knowledge our argumentation scholars have no data on which to base their arguments for more or less curricular attention to this subject matter.

So, while the influence of argumentation studies on the communication discipline is difficult to deny—that impact has been explored in our disciplinary histories (e.g., Gehrke, 2009)—the extent of that influence on contemporary communication pedagogy and, especially, curricula has not been considered in any empirical way, especially in recent years. No readily available project provides information even roughly comparable to that

made available by Morreale and her colleagues for the basic communication course or by Treadwell and Applbaum (1996) for the organizational communication course. This study attempts to address this shortage of information by assessing the continuing disciplinary support for the argumentation course.

In this study, we examine the current state of the argumentation course in communication programs at four-year colleges and universities in the United States. We do so by examining course catalogs, departmental websites, and argumentation course syllabi. Because of the historic association between curricular and co-curricular argumentation instruction, we also attempt to assess the existence of forensic programs.

Literature Review

In argumentation courses, sometimes called courses in debating, the concentration is on the basic principles of advocacy. The student is trained in the process of analyzing stated propositions, in methods of selecting and arranging material in constructive argument and refutation, in tests of evidence and rules of reasoning, and in factors of oral presentation. (Williams, 1955, p. 398)

The early influence of the study of argumentation and debate on the emerging discipline called speech is undeniable. When Williams wrote these words over a half-century ago, he was describing a settled and familiar course in argumentation and debate, with which he assumed his disciplinary audience would be familiar. By the mid-twentieth century, argumentation courses had been normalized.

This process of normalization has been recounted elsewhere in rich detail (e.g., Keith, 2007), and we provide only three examples to illustrate the rise of the argumentation course. Initially, Mary Yost (1917), perhaps the first recipient of a doctorate in the discipline (see Bordelon, 2005), described a 1916 meeting of the nascent National Association of Academic Teachers of

Public Speaking as devoting significant attention to instruction in argumentation: “Nowhere else in the whole field of public speaking are there problems of theory and method more far reaching or ones at present less satisfactorily solved” (p. 109). Fifteen years later, Rowell (1932a, 1932b) would publish a four-article series on argumentation instruction, complete with a description of the typical course in argumentation then taught in what was called the speech discipline. Like Yost before him, Rowell described the standard textbooks used in teaching this course, which was frequently offered in speech departments and programs. Textbooks written by disciplinary sources, including leading scholars like Hoyt H. Hudson (Reeves & Hudson, 1941), would become increasingly available. Further, national forensic honorary organizations such as Pi Kappa Delta were actively promoting intercollegiate forensic competition well before the onset of World War Two.¹ By the 1950s, descriptions of the argumentation course like that supplied above by Williams would resonate with readers of *Quarterly Journal of Speech*, one of the discipline’s oldest academic journals.

While the argumentation course continued to play a settled role in the curriculum, intercollegiate debating developed and evolved over time, with disciplinary textbooks and courses in argumentation responding to changes in tournament practice and argument selection. This development is not surprising, as the debate team coaches and administrators frequently were expected to be the instructors of the institution’s argumentation course or courses, and interest in both argumentation theory and academic debate practice was commonplace. For example, Douglas Ehninger (1958) devoted a lengthy essay to the sophisticated disciplinary dispute over switch-side

¹ Pi Kappa Delta is the oldest such organization. See www.pikappadelta.com.

debating² in tournament practice a year before attempting a much more conceptual defense of debate itself (Ehninger, 1959) and five years before co-authoring one of the best-known disciplinary argumentation textbooks of the twentieth century (Ehninger & Brockriede, 1963). This textbook was built on their earlier essay introducing the work of Stephen Toulmin to disciplinary argumentation studies (Brockriede & Ehninger, 1960).

Interest in both tournament debating and the argumentation course is easy to find in the latter portion of the twentieth century, with such academic journals as *Contemporary Argumentation and Debate* and *Journal of the American Forensic Association* (now *Argumentation and Advocacy*), for example, largely devoted to argumentation and debate theory and pedagogy.³ The organization of the Alta argumentation conferences, beginning in 1979, demonstrated the common interest of communication scholars trained in both social-scientific and humanistic research traditions in argumentation studies, though these common interests were not always recognized a decade earlier (Sanders, 1969). Benoit and Follert (1986) found that graduate courses in argumentation theory were responding to and teaching the contemporary disciplinary research dealing with argumentation.

However, we cannot assume the argumentation course remains today a standard component or mainstay of the communication curriculum. Relative to other specializations in the discipline, Clavier and his colleagues reported in 1979 a 6% decline in hiring of debate and argumentation faculty over a 12-year period

² The switch-side debating controversy is summarized by Greene and Hicks (2005), Harrigan (2008) and Mitchell (2010).

³ We include all forms of competitive debate in our discussion, including the various forms of team policy and non-policy debate, Lincoln-Douglas debate, and parliamentary debate.

³ This study did not identify on-campus debate programs or other campus events that had a debate or advocacy focus.

(Clavier, Clevenger, Khair, & Khair, 1979). More recently, in a study of the 1994 Speech Communication Association's graduate directory, Shelton (1997) found that master's and doctoral specializations in argumentation were less common than specializations in organizational communication, political communication, interpersonal communication, intercultural communication, and several other research areas. Smith and Turner (1993) found 43% of the named communication departments in their sample did not offer coursework in debate. Finally, in a study of communication programs at liberal arts colleges located in the Midwest and South, McGee and Socha McGee (2006) found that just over half of the institutions in their sample offered courses in argumentation; undergraduate courses that became common only after the 1960s, such as organizational communication and interpersonal communication, were more commonly found in the course catalogs of these liberal arts colleges than was the argumentation course.

Given the substantial number of communication programs created in the 1970s and after, along with the growth of interest in other sub-fields and specializations, the argumentation course may be less commonly found in communication curricula than once might have been the case. This study is designed to examine the frequency with which the argumentation course currently appears in course listings for disciplinary programs and provides data on the shape and orientation of undergraduate and graduate argumentation courses at U.S. college and university communication programs.

Method

Our study proceeded in two parts. The first part of the study reviewed college and university websites in search of university course catalogs and other information that would shed light on argumentation instruction at those institutions. The second part of the study retrieved argumentation course syllabi posted on the Internet. These syllabi were evaluated to determine

what textbooks, course objectives, and course designs are employed most commonly for disciplinary instruction in argumentation.

The National Communication Association (NCA), formerly the Speech Communication Association, represents the academic tradition that has studied orality, public speaking, and debate in the United States ever since NCA's founding in 1914. Beginning with the list of current member schools, departments, and programs available on the National Communication Association website, we sought to identify a population of communication programs to sample for purposes of this analysis. From this list, we eliminated all identifiable two-year community and junior colleges, medical schools, and international institutions. Community and junior colleges were eliminated for two reasons. First, the relatively small number of such colleges who paid NCA membership dues led us to suspect the NCA member institutions were not representative of all such institutions, and that a different sampling method might be more appropriate for reviewing the state of argumentation courses at such institutions. Second, because debate courses often are junior and senior courses, we were concerned that debate courses might be excluded from the course inventories of two-year institutions because of system rules or state guidelines, rather than from any lack of commitment to or interest in offering such courses.

For universities listing multiple communication, mass communication, journalism, or other programs as NCA institutional members, we selected the department or program at that university we believed was most likely to represent the speech/orality tradition from which the National Communication Association emerged. (This was typically the department or program offering an entry-level public speaking course.) We then excluded the other academic units from this population.

This work yielded a population of 373 schools, departments, and programs. Each institution was then assigned a number, and a random-number generator was

used to select a sample of 150 institutions, or 40% of the identified population, from which to collect data. A student was trained to retrieve and print department or program information, forensic team data where applicable, and argumentation course descriptions and syllabi where available. For our purposes, all courses using the words “argumentation,” “debate,” and “forensic” were included in the initial collection of data, with courses using the terms “argumentation” and “persuasion” included in the data set for argumentation courses.

Once the data were gathered, the student was then trained by one of the faculty authors in data collection for this project, with initial joint coding sessions intended to resolve conflicts and address any confusion in reviewing the data. The student used an inventory sheet to identify the following:

1. The name of the department or other academic unit sampled;
2. The degrees offered by the department;
3. The tracks or specialization in the major (e.g., organizational, mass media, etc.);
4. Each undergraduate and graduate argumentation, debate, and forensic course with its number and title;
5. The existence of any intercollegiate forensic program;
6. The type of competitive events in which the forensic team competed (debate only, individual events only, or both debate and individual events)⁴.

To the fullest extent possible, all material relevant to the course inventory at each institution was retrieved. After data were entered into the spread sheet, one of the authors checked the course inventory against the Web material and revisited the website if information was inconsistent or missing. The lack of a printed list of

⁴ This study did not identify on-campus debate programs or other campus events that had a debate or advocacy focus.

graduate courses was the most common reason for review. Another reason for review was to verify the existence or type of forensic program. The trigger for such review was usually an inconsistency (e.g., an institution offering a debate or forensic practicum was identified as having no debate or forensic team). To confirm that coding directions had been followed, another author checked 10% of the sample for which all information was consistent and available.

For comparison purposes, data also were collected for undergraduate and graduate persuasion courses at the institutions in the sample. The persuasion course, whether focusing on theories of persuasion and social influence or, more narrowly, the practice of persuasive speaking, is a relatively recent addition to communication curricula when compared with the argumentation course; the separate persuasion course is a mid-twentieth-century development. As late as 1967, Kibler, Gibson, and Hunter (1967) reported that only 40% of the speech departments in their sample offered a separate course in persuasion. Because McGee and Socha McGee (2006) found the persuasion course was more commonly offered than the argumentation course in their study of communication programs at liberal arts colleges, comparison of persuasion and argumentation courses at present should provide some limited sense of the change in communication curricula over time.⁵

⁵ As observed by one reviewer, persuasion courses might differ wildly from one institution to another. Some universities offer persuasion courses with a humanistic, rhetorical emphasis, while other institutions provide persuasion courses with a focus on social-scientific research. Still other universities offer persuasion courses that survey both humanistic and social-scientific perspectives. The comparison of persuasion courses with argumentation and debate courses is intended only to illustrate, however imperfectly, the relative prevalence over time of these two courses in communication undergraduate curricula, given that argumentation courses long predated the emergence of persuasion courses in the discipline. The absence of a common baseline study in any previous decade limits the utility of this approach.

In addition to the data collection described above, an Internet search engine was used to seek out syllabi for argumentation courses taught in communication programs, with no more than one syllabus from the same faculty member included in the sample. This method was employed because very few syllabi were available online for communication programs contained in the sample described above. Using several combinations of search terms, 30 syllabi were retrieved for courses containing the words “argumentation,” “debate,” and “forensics” in the course title, with syllabi showing dates for instruction ranging from 1996 to 2009. Syllabi for courses focusing exclusively on forensics or taught at community or other two-year colleges were excluded from this analysis, for reasons explained previously, as were syllabi for courses taught at non-U.S. institutions. One of the authors then coded these syllabi for required textbooks, coverage of selected topics, and features of course design. When a student not otherwise involved in the project was separately trained and coded 30% of the sample, the percentage-of-agreement score was 91%.

Results

Findings are reported below for the frequency with which argumentation courses and persuasion courses are listed in college catalogs, the nature of course titles assigned to undergraduate argumentation courses, the existence of forensic programs, and the features of undergraduate argumentation course syllabi.

The Sample

The degree data were coded based upon the highest degree offered by the institution. The sample yielded data from 68 programs that granted bachelor's degrees in communication, 52 programs that offered a master's degree in communication, and 28 programs that granted doctoral degrees in communication. One institution offered an undergraduate minor and a master's degree in communication, with no undergraduate major in communication, while another

school offered communication courses, but no degree. These schools were eliminated from the sample, yielding a final sample of 148 institutions, or 39.7% of the identified population.

The Argumentation Course

Of the 68 institutions granting only bachelor's degrees, 53 (77.94%) offered at least one course in argumentation. For all 148 institutions in the sample that granted the bachelor's degree, 133 (89.99%) offered at least one undergraduate course in argumentation. The average number of undergraduate argumentation courses taught was 1.22, with a range of 0 to 5.

Of the master's-granting institutions, ten (19.23%) offered a graduate course in argumentation. Of the doctoral-granting institutions, nine (32.14%) offered a graduate course. Three (3.75%) graduate programs, all doctoral, offered more than one graduate course in argumentation (range 0-3). Overall, 19 (23.75%) of the sampled graduate programs offered a graduate course in argumentation.

The Persuasion Course

Of the 68 institutions granting only bachelor's degrees, 61 (89.71%) offered at least one course in persuasion. For all 148 institutions in the sample that granted the bachelor's degree, 133 (89.99%) offered at least one undergraduate course in persuasion. The average number of undergraduate persuasion courses listed was 1.14, with a range of 0 to 3.⁶

Of the master's-granting institutions, 23 (44.23%) offered a graduate course in persuasion. Of the doctoral-granting institutions, 14 (50.0%) offered a graduate course in persuasion. Only seven graduate programs, five doctoral and two master's, offered more than one graduate course in persuasion (range 0-2). Overall, 37 (46.25%) of the graduate programs sampled offered a graduate course in persuasion.

Undergraduate Argumentation Course Titles

Tendencies in the assignment of course titles can change over time, even for the most traditional of undergraduate communication courses. Significant variations in course titles might indicate the emergence of curricular innovations, distinct differences in teaching philosophy, or the combination of previously separate courses in a single hybrid course. However, "argumentation and debate" remains by far the most common title for the undergraduate argumentation course, followed by "argumentation," and "argumentation and advocacy."

⁶ In response to a reviewer's suggestion, one of the authors reviewed the persuasion course descriptions sampled for this study to determine whether or not the relevant descriptions had a clear preference for a humanistic, social-scientific, or combined humanistic and social-scientific approach to offering the persuasion course. The brevity of many course descriptions in undergraduate and graduate catalogs made such determinations difficult. When a graduate student with no prior association with the study was trained in this coding scheme and separately assessed the relevant course descriptions, the coders were unable to achieve a percentage of agreement score of 80% or higher.

Most course titles found in the sample for undergraduate courses suggest trivial variations in naming (e.g., “fundamentals of argumentation,” “fundamentals of argumentation and debate,” “advocacy and argument”), rather than any distinct disciplinary trends. Frequencies for undergraduate argumentation course titles appear in Table 1.

Table 1: List of Undergraduate Argumentation Course Titles in Order of Frequency

<u>Course Title</u>	<u>No. of Institutions</u>
Argumentation and Debate	45
Argumentation	27
Argumentation and Advocacy	9
Advanced Argumentation	5
Argumentation Theory	5
Advanced Debate	3
Argument and Debate	3
Debate	3
Theories of Argument	3
All Other Course Titles	69
Total Course Titles	172

Notes: Undergraduate course titles containing the words “topics,” “seminar,” “practicum,” “intercollegiate,” and/or “forensics” were excluded from this summary, as were courses with English prefixes. All identical course titles used for at least three different institutions are reported.

Forensic Programs

Of the 148 institutions that granted a bachelor’s degree, 82 (55.41%) had a debate or forensic program of some sort. Among graduate programs, 33 (63.46%) of the masters-only programs and 19 (67.86%) of the doctoral programs had a debate or forensic program. Overall, of the 80 graduate programs sampled, 52 (65.0%) had a debate and/or forensic program. A summary of the types of forensic programs (e.g., debate only, debate and individual events) is provided in Table 2.

Table 2: Forensic Programs

<u>Type of Forensic Program</u>	<u># of Institutions</u>
Debate Team	26
Individual Event Team	10
Both Debate & IE	45
Total Forensic Programs	82*

*Based on the materials made available on the institutional website, the activities supported by one forensic program could not be determined.

Argumentation Course Syllabi

The most common topics for the 30 undergraduate course syllabi examined for this study included various aspects of intercollegiate debate theory; participation in classroom debates; the influence of theorist Stephen Toulmin; and fact, value, and policy propositions. A complete summary of these themes appears in Table 3.

Table 3: Common Topics in Argumentation Course Syllabi

<u>Course Topic*</u>	<u>Frequency</u>
Classroom Intercollegiate	18
Debate Theory **	
Debates	14
Fallacies of Reasoning	12
Influence of Stephen	12
Toulmin/Toulmin Mode	
Fact, Value, or Policy	10
Propositions	
Critical Thinking and	9
Reasoning	
Tournament Debating***	6

*30 syllabi were examined.

**Intercollegiate debate theory included competitive debate formats (e.g., team policy debate) and specific concepts from tournament debate theory and practice (e.g., topicality, flowing and note-taking techniques).

***Tournament debating included optional or mandatory student observations at a debate tournament and/or participation as a competitor.

No dominant textbook appeared in these syllabi. Five syllabi listed Rybacki and Rybacki (2008) as the required text. Four syllabi required the use of Inch, Warnick, and Endres (2005). Three syllabi required Rieke, Sillars, and Peterson (2008), with another three syllabi listing Freeley and Steinberg (2004) as a required textbook. All other textbooks were listed only once or twice. Many syllabi made no reference to reading assignments or described reading assignments made available using an electronic learning management system.

Discussion

As noted below, these research findings should be interpreted with caution. This study suggests that undergraduate argumentation courses are more common features of contemporary communication curricula than has been suggested by previous research. The undergraduate argumentation course is even more prevalent at institutions with communication graduate programs than at institutions offering only the bachelor's degree in communication. If we assume that institutions with graduate programs are training the next generation of faculty and, as a result, might set the agenda for curricular evolution and reform, the undergraduate argumentation course does not appear to be threatened.

However, with a mean of 1.21 argumentation courses and a median of 1.00 argumentation course(s) per program, the typical communication department at a four-year college or university does not supply a diverse array of courses with an argumentation focus if one excludes "topics" or "seminar" titles. The argumentation course is a staple of undergraduate communication programs, but very few colleges or universities appear to have developed any undergraduate curricular depth in this area, even at master's- and doctoral-granting institutions. This course most commonly retains something like the course name it has had for decades, "argumentation and debate," which suggests the course

is not evolving or at the center of any curricular innovations.⁷ Not surprisingly, the paucity of graduate courses addressing argumentation suggests this subject is not an area of curricular specialization for the great majority of graduate programs in the discipline. While we have no evidence that more than one undergraduate or graduate course is required to achieve any particular benchmark for competency in argumentation theory and practice, we could imagine that multiple opportunities for study might encourage graduate students, for example, to specialize in argumentation studies or develop a research or teaching competency in this area. More data would be helpful in assessing the relationship between the number of courses available, the number of courses taken, and any specific learning outcomes or disciplinary outcomes.

Consistent with the findings of McGee and Socha McGee (2006), the persuasion course is even more commonplace in the undergraduate communication curricula than is the argumentation course. While the argumentation course can hardly be described as having lost ground or influence, the persuasion course appears to equal or exceed the argumentation course's role in undergraduate and graduate disciplinary curricula. Indeed, while only 19 (23.75%) graduate programs had at least one course in argumentation, 37 (46.25%), almost twice as many had at least one graduate course in persuasion. If anything, this analysis understates the dominance of the persuasion course, as a few courses in "argumentation and persuasion" were coded here as argumentation courses. In addition, there was no attempt to include courses in social influence in this study unless a course also included the word "persuasion" in the title,

⁷ As suggested by one reviewer, a traditional name for the argumentation course, by itself, would not suggest that completion of the course meets a general-education or programmatic requirement for diversity instruction, civic engagement, or debate across the curriculum. Some of these requirements were pioneered decades after the argumentation course was added to university curricula.

despite the frequent use of “social influence” as a more contemporary proxy for the older “persuasion.”

This study provides no evidence that the dominant position of persuasion courses trades off in some fashion with instruction in argumentation and debate. Both courses are commonplace in undergraduate curricula, for example. However, it is possible that some scholars find the skills and competencies developed in argumentation courses easier to defend on normative grounds than the broader agenda of the persuasion course, given the anxieties described by Schrier (1930) as an “interest in [the] chronic problem of the ethics of persuasion” (p. 476). A preference for argumentation instruction over treatment of character-centered and emotional appeals is not new to disciplinary discussions. To frame this tension between the argumentation and persuasion courses in a slightly different way, O’Keefe (2007) expresses some concern about the possibility of an “intrinsic conflict between normatively-sound argumentation practices and practical persuasive success” (p. 151). The scholar who prefers normatively sound approaches over practical success might bemoan the relative rise in influence of persuasion courses and persuasive effects research.

On a different point, over half the institutions in this sample had some sort of forensic program. However, the pervasiveness of argumentation courses in this sample makes it impossible to assess the impact of a forensic program on the inclusion of an argumentation course in the communication curriculum. Our data do suggest that institutions offering graduate degrees in communication are more likely to have forensic programs than those institutions only offering the bachelor’s degree, but our data do not allow us to isolate any one explanation for this finding. Our data also do not speak to the size or sophistication of those forensic programs or to the involvement of forensic program faculty with the faculty developing argumentation courses at those same institutions.

The review of argumentation course syllabi was hampered by the limited number of such syllabi available in some retrievable form on the Internet. In general, these syllabi suggest a strong focus on the integration of theory and practice, with substantial references to and assignments for in-class debating. The references to Stephen Toulmin in many of these syllabi are consistent with the findings of Benoit and Follert (1986) over two decades ago, where an emphasis on Toulmin's work was common to an overwhelming majority of graduate argumentation courses. A future study that actively solicits argumentation syllabi from the faculty teaching such courses and, as a result, operates with a larger data set, would be advisable. The incompleteness of many assignment descriptions prevented us from pursuing more interesting possibilities for assessing in-class practice for debating or completing written work.

In reviewing these research findings, a number of limitations should be considered. First, our findings provide a snapshot of the argumentation courses at the institutions from which data were collected. Such research does not capture general trends or the evolution of argumentation courses over time, yet longitudinal data are required for a more complete picture of communication pedagogy in any one area. Even in cases where earlier data are available (e.g., Kepler, Gibson, & Hunter, 1967), differences in data collection make data comparisons difficult.

Second, the population we investigated is composed of NCA member institutions. These institutions, which pay the institutional member annual dues, generally may be more committed to the speech/orality tradition than are non-member communication departments or programs. As a consequence, these institutions may be more likely to offer traditional courses than are other institutions without those speech/orality commitments. Argumentation presumably is such a traditional course. This limitation may explain any discrepancies between

this study and earlier studies (e.g., McGee & Socha McGee, 2006).

Third, our data collection for forensic programs did not attempt to identify the number of faculty and students working in the program, the level of competitive success, or frequency of student travel. While over half the institutions in this sample claimed to have some sort of forensic program, simply noting the existence of such programs is likely to mask huge differences where these programs are concerned. In addition, the same bias to the speech/orality tradition that might make a department or program join the National Communication Association might also make this population (and sample) especially likely to support a forensic program.

Fourth, the argumentation course syllabi considered here have all the usual problems of both a small sample and a convenience sample. As a result, our findings are, at best, only suggestive. For example, only technology-friendly instructors are likely to post course syllabi to the Internet, and such faculty may not be representative of all those teaching the argumentation course. Further, many syllabi presumably are only available in Intranet or password-protected environments and cannot be retrieved using Internet search tools. Finally, some syllabi are far more complete than others in the description of course topics and content, which raises problems in determining what materials are taught in those course sections. The direct solicitation of course syllabi from programs offering the argumentation course should be considered when future studies of the argumentation course are designed, along with research projects that survey argumentation instructors about their course features and pedagogies.

Fifth, many two-year institutions offer courses in argumentation and debate. Multiple course syllabi from such institutions (e.g., Modesto Junior College) were excluded from this analysis. The focus of this study on four-year institutions provides an incomplete assessment of undergraduate argumentation and debate instruction

in the discipline. Future studies ideally will address this gap in our knowledge.

Sixth, that a course is listed in a catalog does not suggest the course is taught frequently, or even taught at all. This study did not include an assessment of whether argumentation courses listed in course catalogs were taught regularly. Also, some institutions may not quickly remove courses from their course inventories, even when there is no intention to offer these courses. Future studies are needed to assess the extent to which the argumentation course is regularly offered to undergraduate and graduate students.⁸

In closing, Makau (1985) noted over twenty years ago that, “perhaps more than any other teacher, the argumentation instructor has the opportunity to teach the reasoning skills fundamental to the preservation of a free society. This teacher has the training, the interest, the tradition, the methodology, and the occasion to teach students the precious, but threatened art of critical thinking” (p. 234). Perhaps for the reasons suggested by Makau, our findings suggest that, whatever the other, dramatic changes in communication theory and pedagogy over time, substantial disciplinary support remains for the argumentation course. While many new specializations have emerged over the past half-century in the discipline of communication, the argumentation

⁸ In attempting to address one reviewer’s concern, a subset of the communication programs in our sample were contacted and asked to describe the frequency with which argumentation courses were offered by their programs. Answers to these questions, when answers were provided, were highly variable. Many institutions, for example, do not have consistent and stable course rotation schemes. Multiple respondents suggested that the most recent three academic years, for example, did not represent the typical or normal commitment of the program to the argumentation course. At a minimum, we confirmed that course availability ranged from “never” to multiple course sections per semester. Soliciting useable data on this point will require careful instrument design and ideally would be incorporated in future studies of argumentation courses.

course remains a staple of the communication curriculum.

References

- Allen, M., Berkowitz, S., Hunt, S., & Loudon, A. (1999). A meta-analysis of the impact of forensics and communication education on critical thinking. *Communication Education*, 48, 18-30
- Benoit, W. L., & Follert, V. F. (1986). Graduate courses in argumentation theory. *Communication Education*, 35, 61-66.
- Bordelon, S. (2005). Contradicting and complicating: Feminization of rhetoric narratives: Mary Yost and argument from a sociological perspective. *Rhetoric Society Quarterly*, 35, 101-124.
- Brockriede, W., & Ehninger, D. (1960). Toulmin on argument: An interpretation and application. *Quarterly Journal of Speech*, 46, 44-53.
- Clavier, D., Clevenger, T., Jr., Khair, S. E., & Khair, M. M. (1979). Twelve-year employment trends for speech communication graduates. *Communication Education*, 28, 305-313.
- Cox, J. R. (1980). Argumentation and human decision-making: Teaching the upper level course. *Speaker and Gavel*, 18, 1-10.
- Ehninger, D. (1958). The debate about debating. *Quarterly Journal of Speech*, 44, 128-136.
- Ehninger, D. (1959). Decision by debate: A re-examination. *Quarterly Journal of Speech*, 45, 282-287.
- Ehninger, D., & Brockriede, W. (1963). *Decision by debate*. New York: Dodd, Mead.
- Freeley, A. J., & Steinberg, D. (2004). *Argumentation and debate: Critical thinking for reasoned decision making* (11th ed.). Belmont, CA: Wadsworth.
- Gehrke, P. (2009). *The ethics and politics of speech: Communication and rhetoric in the 20th century*. Carbondale: Southern Illinois University Press.

- Greene, R. W., & Hicks, D. (2005). Lost convictions: Debating both sides and the ethical self-fashioning of liberal citizens. *Cultural Studies*, 19, 100-126.
- Harrigan, C. (2008). Stronger than ever: A defense of switch-side Debate. *Contemporary Argumentation & Debate*, 29, 37-67.
- Heisey, D. R. (1968). An honors course in argumentation. *Speech Teacher*, 17, 202-204.
- Inch, E. S., Warnick, B., & Endres, D. (2005). *Critical thinking and communication: The use of reason in argument* (5th ed.). New York: Allyn & Bacon.
- Keith, W. M. (2007). *Democracy as discussion: Civic education and the American forum movement*. Lanham, MD: Lexington.
- Kibler, R. J., Gibson, J. W., & Hunter, E. C. (1967). The current status of persuasion courses in American colleges and universities. *Speech Teacher*, 16, 137-142.
- Makau, J. M. (1985). Adapting the judicial model of reasoning to the basic argumentation and debate course. *Communication Education*, 34, 227-234.
- McGee, B. R., & Socha McGee, D. (2006). The small-college communication program: An assessment of communication program organization and curricula at private liberal arts colleges in the Midwest and South. *Speaker and Gavel*, 43, 36-45.
- Mitchell, G. R. (2010). Switch-side debating meets demand-driven rhetoric of science. *Rhetoric and public affairs*, 13, 95-120.
- Morreale, S., Hugenberg, L., & Worley, D. (2006). The basic communication course at U.S. colleges and universities in the 21st century: Study VII. *Communication Education*, 55, 415-437.
- O'Keefe, D. J. (2007). Potential conflicts between normatively-responsible advocacy and successful social influence: Evidence from persuasion effects research. *Argumentation*, 21, 151-163.
- Reeves, J. W., & Hudson, H. H. (1941). *Principles of argument and debate*. Boston: D. C. Heath.
- Rieke, R. D., Sillars, M. O., & Peterson, T. R. (2008). *Argumentation and critical decision making* (7th ed.). Boston: Allyn and Bacon.

- Rowell, E. Z. (1932a). Prolegomena to argumentation. *Quarterly Journal of Speech*, 18, 1-13.
- Rowell, E. Z. (1932b). Prolegomena to argumentation. *Quarterly Journal of Speech*, 18, 381-405.
- Rybacki, K. C., & Rybacki, D. J. (2008). *Advocacy and opposition: An introduction to argumentation* (6th ed.). New York: Allyn & Bacon.
- Sanders, J. A., Wiseman, R. L., & Gass, R. H. (1994). Does teaching argumentation facilitate critical thinking? *Communication Reports*, 7, 27-35.
- Sanders, K. R. (1969). [Review of Readings in Argumentation.] *Philosophy & Rhetoric*, 2, 247-248.
- Schrier, W. (1930). The ethics of persuasion (a defense of rhetoric). *Quarterly Journal of Speech*, 16, 476-486.
- Shelton, M. (1997). Graduate study in the communication discipline: An extension of 1994 directory data. *Journal of the Association of Communication Administration*, 1, 69-75.
- Smith, D. K. (1954). Origin and development of departments of speech. In K. R. Wallace (Ed.), *History of Speech Education in America* (pp. 447-470). New York: Appleton-Century-Crofts.
- Smith, J. H., & Turner, P. H. (1993, January). A survey of communication department curriculum at four-year colleges and universities. *Journal of the Association for Communication Administration*, 1, 34-49.
- Treadwell, D., & Applbaum, R. L. The basic course in organizational communication: A national survey. *Journal of the Association for Communication Administration*, 1, 12-24.
- Warnick, B. (1980). The argumentation and debate course in the 1980's. *Speaker and Gavel*, 17, 155-161.
- Williams, D. E. (1955). Group discussion and argumentation in legal education. *Quarterly Journal of Speech*, 41, 397-402.
- Williams, D. E., & McGee, B. R. (2000). Negotiating a change in the argumentation course: Teaching cooperative argument. *Argumentation and Advocacy*, 36, 105-119.
- Yost, M. (1917). Argument from the point-of-view of sociology. *Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking*, 3, 109-124.

Zompetti, J. P. (2006). The role of advocacy in civil society. *Argumentation*, 20, 167-183.

Deborah Socha McGee (Ph.D., Ohio State) is Associate Professor and Director of the Speaking Lab and Brian R. McGee (Ph.D., Ohio State) is Chief of Staff and Senior Policy Advisor, Office of the President, College of Charleston. Mary Catherine Kennedy (B.A., College of Charleston) is a graduate student in the School of Media Arts and Studies, Ohio University. An early version of this paper was presented at the meeting of the National Communication Association. We thank the CAD editors and reviewers for their very helpful suggestions for the revision of this paper.

Copyright of Contemporary Argumentation & Debate is the property of Cross Examination Debate Association and its content may not be copied or emailed to multiple sites or posted to a listserv without the copyright holder's express written permission. However, users may print, download, or email articles for individual use.